

HM 402. Publics in South Asia: Contemporary Perspectives

Winter 2025-26

Instructor: Dr. Shefali Jha

Course Placement: HM 402 is an Open Elective

Course Format: 3 hours of lectures each week.

Pre-requisites: None

Course Content

We all assume that we are part of something called ‘the public’, and assume its existence in our roles as students, teachers, ‘fans’, citizens/ ‘netizens’, readers, spectators and so on. Nobody invites us to become members, nor can anyone take away our participation in the public, active or passive. Publics are at the heart of the democratic imagination: Just as we cannot imagine modern politics without democracy, democracy has little meaning without ‘the public.’

Why and how did this come to be? What the various practices and technologies through which we come to be members of publics? What are the spaces and representations of people, cultures and events, through which we may identify and analyse publics? Who draws the line between the public and the private, and why is that line important? What significance do national boundaries and histories have for such analyses? This course is based on exploring these fundamental questions with the help of readings taken from recent ethnographic work by anthropologists of Bangladesh, Nepal, Pakistan, India and Sri Lanka, aside from historical accounts and political theory. We will see whether there are threads of similarity which run through the social worlds of class, caste, gender, and sexuality in the region, and how these affect our ways of thinking about publics, publicity, and privacy. We will read about and work with the written word, films, music and radio performances to discuss these questions.

Course Material (Selected):

1. *Global Digital Futures*. Edited by Aswin Punthambekar and Sriram Mohan. University of Michigan Press, 2017.
2. *Habermas and the Public Sphere*. Edited by Craig Calhoun. MIT Press, 1992.
3. *Music and Dance as Everyday South Asia*. Edited by Sarah H. Morelli and Zoe Sherinian. OUP, 2024.

4. Kant, Immanuel. 1784. "An Answer to the Question: What is Enlightenment?" Translated by James Schmidt. In *What is Enlightenment? Eighteenth Century Answers and Twentieth-Century Questions*, edited by James Schmidt. University of California Press, 1996.
5. Kaviraj, Sudipta. 2014. 'A Strange Love of the Land: Identity, Poetry and Politics in the (Un)Making of South Asia.' *South Asia Multidisciplinary Academic Journal* [Online], 10. <http://journals.openedition.org/samaj/3826>; doi : 10.4000/samaj.3756
6. Warner, Michael. "Publics and Counterpublics." *Public Culture* 14 (1): 49- 90.

Method of Assessment: Class Participation (20%); Class Presentation + write-up (10 + 20%); Reviews + Response papers (20%); final paper to be written in class (30%).

Participation will be judged by attendance, tasks, as well as helpful and relevant interventions in class discussion.

Plagiarism on assignments and unacknowledged, thoughtless use of AI tools will result in a failing grade for the course.

Course Outcomes: On successfully completing the course, students will have a basic familiarity with India's neighbouring states and the socio-cultural fabric of South Asian societies. They will be able to reflect on their own experience, perspectives and responsibilities as future knowledge workers and citizens. They will also be able to read and think with research material in the social sciences, becoming conversant with ethnography as a method of research. Their writing and analytical skills should improve, and they should learn the skill of communicating complex ideas to different kinds of audiences.

P1	P2	P3	P4	P5	P6	P7	P8	P9	P10	P11	P12
			X		X	X	X	X	X		X

Lecture Schedule

Sr. No.	Description	No. of Lectures
I.	Introduction: Framing Concepts	10- 12
	Enlightenment Legacies: What is Public Reason?	
	Habermas and the Public Sphere Debate	

	Where is South Asia?	
	Publics and the Public Sphere in India: Debates	
II.	Space	10
	Public and Private Space	
	Urban spaces: class and gendered mobility	
	Digital publics	
III.	Words in the World	10
	The printed word: language and group identity	
	Time and Circulation	
	Scandal and Gossip: circulation by other means	
IV.	Arts of the Public	10
	Popular Music and Performance Art	
	Cinema posters and visual cities	
	Female stardom; censorship and sexuality	